

BIRTHDAY QUEST - GAME MASTER'S GUIDE + PLAYER PACK

The Lost Celebration of Bellweather

A fantasy one-shot about rebuilding a forgotten town tradition—without knowing what it will become

3 HEROES	Level 3 QUICK-PLAY	3½-4½h RUN TIME	Age 13 AGE-TUNED
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THE PROMISE

Bellweather's grand celebration item was lost generations ago. The heroes must recover four cryptically named components, survive creatures that want the tradition forgotten, and rebuild the mystery beneath a sealed stone dome.

What is included

- A complete scene-by-scene mystery quest with read-aloud text and an expected three-and-a-half-to-four-and-a-half-hour run of show.
- Ingredient hunts featuring battle, stealth, negotiation, and a fail-forward reconstruction finale.
- Three simplified level 3 heroes: a protector, a sneak, and a starry bard.
- Printable handouts, official 2024 character sheets, quick rules, keyed maps, tokens, and complete creature stat blocks.
- Experience, difficulty, and two-player adjustments so the game stays fun rather than fragile.

Assumptions

This packet uses the 2024 fifth-edition D&D rules for three level 3 heroes and one Game Master. The mystery should feel adventurous rather than childish. Use DC 12 for routine challenges and DC 13 when pressure matters.

QUICK PERSONALIZE

Handwrite the birthday hero's name on the commission. Place a covered cake nearby if desired. Players may guess freely; NPCs cannot confirm the answer before the Founder's Hearth opens.

Game Master's Quick Start

You can run the adventure directly from these pages. For each scene: read the boxed text, ask 'What do you do?', let everyone answer, then call for a roll only when failure would be interesting. If you forget a rule, choose DC 12, make a fair ruling, and keep the story moving.

Before everyone arrives

- Print the official hero sheets, hero action cards, spell cards, maps, tokens, component cards, loot cards, trackers, and Player Quick Rules page.
- Gather one d20 per player plus d4, d6, d8, and d10 dice. Cut out the creature, component, reward, Heroic Inspiration, condition, and hearth-rune pieces. Give each player Heroic Inspiration.
- This age 13 version uses DC 12 for routine checks and DC 13 for risky or dramatic checks. If everyone is new, DC 12 throughout is fine.
- Privately ask whether anything should stay out of the story. Keep scares cartoony and allow anyone to pause the game without explanation.
- Let the birthday child choose a hero first. Give the remaining heroes equal chances to solve problems and make decisions.

Four-hour run of show (expect 3½ to 4½ hours)

Time	Scene	What matters
0:00	Welcome and hero choice	Introduce characters, explain the d20, and present the restoration tablet.
0:20	Act 1: Briar Farm	Battle or outwit evil moon-hens to recover the Dawn Pearls.
1:20	Act 2A: Storehouse	Sneak past guards or earn their trust to collect Lantern Gold.
2:10	Break / Short Rest	Pause, recap clues, spend Hit Dice, and recover Short Rest features.
2:20	Act 2B: Mill and Honey Steps	Solve the chute puzzle; bargain or battle for Sunmeal and Cloudsweet.
3:35	Act 3: Founder's Hearth	Combine the components and defend four hearth runes from Cindermaw.

Time	Scene	What matters
4:45	Epilogue	Open the dome, reveal the cake, award the Restorer's Medal, and celebrate.

The three golden rules

1. Say yes to good ideas. If an action is plausible and fun, let it work or call for a DC 10-13 check.
2. Failure changes the situation; it never stops the adventure. Reveal the clue, but add a cost, complication, or funny consequence.
3. End fights early when the outcome is clear. Enemies surrender, flee, or tumble into harmless feathers and soot at 0 hit points.

HEROIC INSPIRATION

Each hero starts with it. Immediately after rolling any die, a hero may expend it to reroll that die and must use the new roll. A hero can have only one Heroic Inspiration at a time.

GM-ONLY SECTION

Secrets, Suspects, and the Lost Recipe

What really happened

Bellweather once welcomed every new year with a magnificent shared creation, but a fire destroyed the guildhall and its records. Mayor Mallow recovered a coded tablet naming Dawn Pearls, Sunmeal, Lantern Gold, and Cloudsweet. They are eggs, flour, food-grade seed oil, and sugar. Cindermau was born in the guildhall fire and believes the rekindled hearth will destroy it. Players may guess the answer; NPCs cannot confirm it until the dome opens.

THE REVEAL

Use component names, but let players guess freely. NPCs genuinely do not know. A correct prediction earns advantage on one Founder's Hearth check; the magical finished creation remains the true reveal.

People and creatures

Name	First impression	What they want / know
Mayor Mallow	Flustered historian with a soot-marked tablet	Wants the lost tradition restored but cannot read the component names.
Captain Wick	Suspicious lamplighter guard with an enormous key ring	Knows brightseed oil is edible; fears thieves are working for Cinderdaw.
Cinderdaw	A coal-black drake leaking sparks and soot	Fears the restored hearth will destroy it. Can become its protector instead.
Moon-hens	Goose-sized black chickens with silver combs	Guard the Dawn Pearls; can be calmed with feed, rhythm, or firm handling.
Sprig	A brave lantern sprite	Optional helper for two heroes or a struggling party.

Clues the heroes cannot miss

- The Dawn Pearls are warm, speckled, and fiercely guarded by enormous black hens.
- Lantern Gold is pressed brightseed oil. Captain Wick knows the gold variety is safe for food; the blue and black lamp fuels are dangerous.
- Sunmeal resembles golden dust and Cloudsweet resembles pale quartz. Smell or taste can reveal more, but never require a player to do so.
- The reconstruction tablet repeatedly mentions mixing, rising warmth, and a final crown—but never names the object.

Useful difficulty numbers

DC	Use it when...	Examples
10	The idea is sensible or the players are younger	Spot an obvious trail, calm a silly creature, leap a short gap.
12	Default challenge	Notice sootling tracks, calm one hen, identify a marked flask.

DC	Use it when...	Examples
13	The attempt is risky, dramatic, or under time pressure	Cross guarded rafters, solve a rune under pressure, resist Soot Breath.

GM-ONLY SECTION

Act 1: The Broken Celebration

Goal: introduce the heroes, reveal the missing tradition, and recover Dawn Pearls. Target time: 60 minutes. Take Break 1 as a Short Rest after the tablet points toward the storehouse.

READ ALOUD

Bellweather Square should be bursting with music, banners, and cheering. Instead, an empty stone pedestal stands beneath a scorched cloth. Mayor Mallow holds up a cracked tablet. 'Heroes, our oldest celebration has been lost so long that nobody remembers what belongs here. The tablet names four pieces. Recover them before tomorrow's sunset, and perhaps the Founder's Hearth can rebuild what we forgot.'

Give everyone a spotlight question

- What strange festival tradition does your hero insist is completely normal?
- What useful tool did your hero bring that nobody else thought to pack?
- Why does rebuilding Bellweather's lost celebration matter to your hero?

Reward a confident or funny answer with a cheer. Every hero already begins with Heroic Inspiration, using the standard 2024 rule.

The mayor's commission

READ ALOUD

At Briar Farm, the barn doors explode outward in a cyclone of feathers. Six enormous black chickens patrol a stone nest. Their eyes glow ember-red. One scratches a warning into the dirt: CLUCK OFF. Behind it rest three warm, speckled objects exactly the size of the tablet's first hollow.

Challenge: Battle the Briar Farm brood

Six magically enraged moon-hens surround a stone nest holding three Dawn Pearls. The group may attempt 4 successes before 2 setbacks or enter combat. In combat, use three hens and the silver-

combed rooster; add two hens after round 2 only if the heroes are winning easily. Calming the rooster ends the encounter.

- Athletics: hold a gate shut, tip a feed trough, or shield an ally from a charging hen.
- Acrobatics or Stealth: cross the rafters, slip behind the brood, or snatch an egg between patrols.
- Animal Handling: imitate the old farmer's calming whistle or scatter feed in a safe direction.
- Investigation or Perception: spot the true nest, the rooster's signal, or a loose fence board.
- Magic, Performance, or another clever plan: judge by the idea, usually DC 10-13.

FAIL FORWARD

On success, the heroes recover the Dawn Pearls cleanly. On a mixed result, they still escape with all three, but a furious rooster follows them and loudly ruins their next attempt at Stealth. Either way, the tablet reveals the clue to Lantern Gold.

Moon-hen — quick combat

AC 12; HP 7 each; Speed 30 ft.; Initiative +2. Furious Peck: +4 to hit, 1d4 + 2 piercing. Once per round, only the rooster may use Wing Flurry: creatures within 5 ft. make a DC 12 Dex save or take 1d4 + 2 bludgeoning and fall prone. The brood flees when three hens fall or the rooster is calmed with a DC 13 Animal Handling or Performance action.

First component recovered

The Dawn Pearls reveal the storehouse clue. If the heroes calmed the rooster, give them the Silver Feather loot card: cancel frightened once. A soot-black drake silhouette watches from a distant chimney, then vanishes.

READ ALOUD — THE TABLET AWAKENS

As the third Dawn Pearl settles into the cracked tablet, silver lines race across its surface. A new sentence burns into view: 'Where watchful eyes guard bottled daylight, claim only the gold that may touch a wooden spoon.' Far across Bellweather, the lamplighter tower flashes once—then goes dark. Ask: 'How do you travel there, and who carries the tablet?'

GM-ONLY SECTION

Act 2: Gold Behind Guarded Doors

Goal: expose the impostor, recover Lantern Gold, solve the windmill, and earn Cloudsweet. Target time: 100-120 minutes. Take Break 2 as an eight-hour Long Rest after all four components are recovered; resume at dawn.

READ ALOUD

The lamplighter storehouse squats beside the city wall, its windows barred and its roof patrolled. Captain Wick checks Mayor Mallow's seal, then lowers his voice. 'The courtyard is safe. The oil room is not. Sootlings can wear a guard's shape, and one of my people casts no shadow. Go quietly. Find the flask marked with a wooden spoon. Trust nobody carrying blue fire.'

Scene A: The Lamplighter Storehouse

Run one shared challenge: 3 successes before 2 setbacks. Ask every hero to describe an approach before anyone repeats a skill. OFFICIAL—work beside Wick and test guards; COVERT—use rafters and the roof vent; BAIT—announce a false target and watch who reacts. Routes can be mixed.

- OFFICIAL: DC 12 Insight, Perception, or Persuasion identifies contradictions, soot tracks, or a missing shadow.
- COVERT: DC 13 Stealth, Acrobatics, or thieves' tools crosses the rafters, opens the vent, or reaches the oil room unseen.
- BAIT: DC 12 Deception, Investigation, Performance, or a clever tool use provokes the impostor or identifies the wooden-spoon seal. After every roll, reveal one useful clue.
- Outcome: at 3 successes, the heroes expose the impostor and preserve Wick's trust. At 2 setbacks, the sootling grabs blue fire and runs; ask every hero for one immediate response. Either way, the correct Lantern Gold is secured. Award Captain's Whistle if no real guard was harmed: once in the finale, one rune is guarded for a full round.

READ ALOUD — LANTERN GOLD RECOVERED

The golden flask bears a tiny wooden-spoon seal. When it touches the tablet, the second symbol shines like sunrise through amber glass. Captain Wick exhales. 'That is the true brightseed oil. Whatever you are restoring, Cindermaw is frightened of it.' A new line points toward the abandoned windmill beyond the west gate.

Bellweather guard — quick combat

AC 14; HP 11 each; Speed 30 ft.; Initiative +1. Spear: +3 to hit, 1d6 + 1 piercing. Net (one use): ranged +3, 10/20 ft.; a hit restrains until the target uses an action and succeeds on DC 10 Strength. Use these statistics only if a disguised sootling starts a scuffle; real guards use nets, Help, and grapples.

READ ALOUD — IF THE ALARM SOUNDS

A brass bell CLANGS overhead. Boots pound across the courtyard. One guard smiles far too widely, dissolves into soot, and races for a rack of blue-burning flasks. Captain Wick shouts, 'That one is not mine! Stop it—and keep the blue fire away from the oil!' Ask each player for one immediate action, then roll initiative only if the chase needs it.

FIRST-TIME GM: RUN THE INFILTRATION

Track 3 **SUCCESS** boxes and 2 **SETBACK** boxes. Ask every hero for an approach before anyone repeats a skill. Nyx can sneak, Bramble can distract, and Elio can question guards. Reveal one clue after every roll. At 3 successes, expose the impostor cleanly. At 2 setbacks, trigger the fleeing sootling. Never block the correct flask.

Scene B: The Windmill and Honey Steps

At the abandoned mill, four marked chutes—Raven, Sun, River, and Crown—must be opened in order to release the preserved Sunmeal. Read the three carved clues:

PUZZLE CLUES

RIVER comes before RAVEN. CROWN stands immediately before SUN. RAVEN is neither first nor last.

Answer: River, Raven, Crown, Sun. A wrong choice releases harmless golden dust and reveals another hint. After two wrong tries, River glows. Solving it without a magical hint awards Millkeeper's Gear: after a failed preparation check, turn that failure into a success.

READ ALOUD — THE MILL TURNS

The final chute locks into place. Ancient gears groan, the sails turn despite the still air, and a drawer slides from the millstone. Inside rests a pouch of golden powder marked **SUNMEAL**. Beneath it is a silver map ending at a stairway of enormous flowers. Tiny winged shapes circle the top. Ask: 'Do you approach openly, hide, or prepare an offering?'

Cloudsweet encounter**READ ALOUD — THE SUGAR SPRITES**

The flower stair ends at a garden of glassy blossoms. Three tiny winged figures rise from the petals, each carrying a needle-thin spear. Their leader points at the tablet. 'Ground-walkers took our flowers and never replanted them. Why should we surrender what remembers their sweetness?' Ask: 'What do you say or offer?'

The sprites accept a song, a specific promise to replant their flowers, or a DC 13 Nature, Performance, or Persuasion check. Otherwise, three sprites attack and bargain when two fall. A sincere promise awards Sprite's Favor. With all four components recovered, the heroes camp beneath the sprites' protective flowers for an eight-hour Long Rest and resume at dawn.

READ ALOUD — ALL FOUR RECOVERED

The pale crystals settle into the tablet's final hollow. All four symbols pulse together, and a path of golden footprints appears on the road toward the ruined guildhall. For one instant the air smells warm and familiar—but the memory slips away before you can name it. The sun touches the rooftops. The Founder's Hearth is waiting.

Act 3: The Founder's Hearth

Goal: solve the Four Channels, operate the hearth as a team, and protect the reconstruction from Cinderdaw. Target time: 90-110 minutes including finale and epilogue.

READ ALOUD

The Founder's Hearth waits beneath the ruined guildhall. Four stone channels lead toward a sealed iron dome. As the components approach, words ignite across the tablet: WHAT WAKES. WHAT GIVES FORM. WHAT CARRIES WARMTH. WHAT REMEMBERS JOY. From the chimney comes a frightened scraping sound. 'Let forgotten things stay forgotten.'

Trial 1: The Four Channels

The recovered portions are already magically measured. The heroes connect each to the correct channel using the tablet: 'What wakes enters first. What gives form follows. Warm gold binds what was divided. Memory crowns the work.' Answer: Dawn Pearls, Sunmeal, Lantern Gold, Cloudsweet. After two mistakes, the correct next channel glows.

Trial 2: Operate and Prepare the Hearth

Give out the COMBINE, STIR, WARM, and CROWN pieces. After the heroes identify the order, each takes a station: tablet reader, stone-hand operator, or heat keeper. Each hero makes exactly one DC 13 preparation check; resolve the result only after all three have acted. Do not run a second preparation challenge.

READ ALOUD — BEGIN THE RECONSTRUCTION

The stone hands complete their final motion. Beneath the dome, something begins to turn. First comes a soft whisking sound, then a slow golden glow. The four hearth runes ignite around the chamber. From the chimney above, claws scrape against brick. Ask each hero where they stand before the creature arrives.

The sealed reconstruction dome

READ ALOUD

Golden light leaks beneath the sealed dome. The air smells warm, rich, and strangely familiar. Cinderdaw crawls headfirst from the chimney, scattering sparks across four glowing runes. 'Stop!' it cries. 'If the old hearth wakes, there will be nowhere left for me!' Two sootlings drop behind it and race toward separate runes. Roll initiative.

Preparation contributions

Count successes after all three heroes make one DC 13 contribution. Millkeeper's Gear can turn one failed contribution into a success. Do not confirm that the rising mixture is a cake; describe scents, warmth, and golden light.

- Arcana: stabilize the old hearth's runes.
- Investigation: align the tablet with the four component channels.
- Performance: reproduce the rhythm shown by the stone stirring hands.
- Survival or History: recognize the purpose of controlled heat and careful measures.
- Any creative action: improvise a missing tool, cool a cracked rune, or protect the covered dome.

PREPARATION RESULT — RESOLVE AFTER ALL THREE HEROES ACT

3 successes: all runes lit; Cinderdaw starts at 42 HP. 2 successes: all runes lit; Cinderdaw starts at 52 HP. 1 success: one rune starts dark; Cinderdaw starts at 52 HP. 0 successes: one rune starts dark and Cinderdaw acts first. The reconstruction is never ruined.

GM-ONLY SECTION

Finale: Cinderdaw and the Four Hearth Runes

Use the Founder's Hearth map, four rune tokens, two sootlings, Cinderdaw, and one progress marker. The heroes win at the end of a round with 3 Reconstruction successes, by reducing Cinderdaw to 0 HP, or—after 2 successes and no earlier than round 3—by convincing it that the hearth can become its home.

Finale rules

FIRST-TIME GM — RUN EACH ROUND

1. Announce lit runes and the hero who may attempt Reconstruction. 2. Let everyone act in initiative order; only one Reconstruction attempt is allowed. 3. A sootling may attack or extinguish a rune. 4. If none does, Cinderdaw smothers one unguarded rune. 5. Check victory only after the round ends.

OPTIONAL RUNE POWERS

PEARL: healing restores +1d4 HP. MEAL: heroes cannot be pushed or knocked prone. GOLD: the first weapon hit each round deals +1d4 radiant. SWEET: heroes have Advantage against Frightened. Use these for the combat-experienced group; omit them if bookkeeping slows play.

- Only one rune can be extinguished per round in total. A sootling may use Foul Rune; if none does, Cinderdaw smothers one unguarded rune at round's end. A hero beside a rune may use an action to relight it or guard it until the hero's next turn.

- Only one Reconstruction check can be attempted each round, and at least 2 runes must be lit. A hero beside the tablet uses an action for a DC 13 fitting check. A different hero must attempt each round until all three have contributed. Success marks MIX, RISE, or FINISH and relights one rune. Progress never resets.
- At 2 successes, Radiant Draft activates: Cinderdaw takes 2d8 radiant damage, every hero ends frightened, and one extinguished rune relights. At 3 successes, finish the current round; then the dome seals, Cinderdaw becomes a Tiny ember-drake, and combat ends.
- If fewer than 2 runes are lit, Reconstruction cannot be attempted. The townspeople's song relights Pearl at round's end if fewer than 2 remain lit. A hero who expends Heroic Inspiration to reroll a failed Reconstruction check also relights one rune, even if the reroll fails.
- After 2 Reconstruction successes and no earlier than round 3, a hero can use an action and make a DC 12 Persuasion check to offer Cinderdaw a home. On success, finish the current round and then end the fight. When Cinderdaw becomes Tiny or reaches 0 HP, ask whether the heroes banish it, let it escape, or appoint it Bellweather's hearth-keeper.

READ ALOUD — CINDERMAW'S CHOICE

The ash drake shrinks until it is no larger than a house cat. Its flames dim to a nervous glow. It looks from the bright hearth to the open chimney. 'I thought waking it would put me out,' it whispers. 'Is there room in your celebration for something made from the fire?' Stop reading. Ask the players what they offer, then choose the ending that follows their answer.

Cinderdaw, Ash Drake

Medium Elemental; AC 14; Initiative +3 (13); HP 52 (42 if preparation succeeded); Speed 30 ft., Climb 20 ft. Saves: Dex +5, Wis +3. Resistance to Fire damage; Immunity to the Frightened condition.

Cinder Claw. Melee Attack Roll: +5, reach 5 ft. Hit: 7 (1d8 + 3) Fire damage.

Soot Breath (Recharge 5-6). Wisdom Saving Throw: DC 13, each creature in a 15-foot Cone. Failure: 7 (2d6) Psychic damage and Frightened until the end of its next turn. Success: Half damage only.

Up the Chimney! (Reaction, once per round). Trigger: Cinderdaw is hit by an attack. Response: it climbs up to 10 feet without provoking Opportunity Attacks.

Tactics. Cinderdaw circles the hearth, targets confident heroes with Soot Breath, and commands sootlings to foul separate runes. It never attacks an unconscious hero. Its threats sound frightened: 'If the hearth wakes, where will I go?' Reveal this after round 1 or a successful DC 12 Insight check.

Sootlings (2)

Tiny elementals; AC 12; HP 5 each; Speed 25 ft., climb 25 ft.; Initiative +2. Smudging Scratch: +4 to hit, 1d4 + 2 psychic damage. Poof! At 0 HP, a sootling bursts into harmless black dust. A hero beside it may catch a golden spark and regain 1d4 HP.

KEEP IT MOVING

At the start of each round, announce lit runes, Reconstruction progress, and which hero may contribute next. If the clock slips, after round 3 advance Reconstruction to FINISH following the next successful compassionate or creative action. Finish the current round, then begin the reveal. Never grind through the last few hit points.

GM-ONLY SECTION

Epilogue, Reveal, and Easy Adjustments

The dome opens

READ ALOUD

The four runes blaze white. With a deep stone rumble, the dome rises. Beneath it stands a towering golden cake made from the Dawn Pearls, Sunmeal, Lantern Gold, and Cloudsweet—finished with shimmering decorations formed from the heroes' own magic. Mayor Mallow laughs. 'Bellweather didn't lose a treasure. We lost the recipe for celebrating together!'

Lift a bowl, box, or cloth at the table if you have prepared a real birthday cake. Beneath the stone dome stands an enormous golden cake crowned with candles. Explain how every quest component became part of it. Ask each player to narrate one decoration created by their hero, then let the birthday child name the finished cake.

Restorer's Medal

Once in a future adventure, the wearer can turn a failed check into a success by explaining what forgotten thing they remembered. Afterward, the medal becomes an ordinary brass gear.

Difficulty and age dial

Group	Checks	Final encounter
New players	Use DC 12; offer a hint after one failed attempt.	Cindermaw HP 44; one sootling; Pearl Rune begins guarded.
Age 13 / default	Use DC 13 and the printed challenges.	Cindermaw HP 52; two sootlings; one rune can be extinguished per round.
Experienced players	Use DC 14; add costs on mixed results.	Cindermaw HP 60; three sootlings; Gold Rune begins dark.

If the table has only two players plus a GM

Each player chooses a hero and starts with Heroic Inspiration. Use Cindermau at 34 HP with one sootling. Sprig follows them: AC 13, HP 15; Star Bolt +5 to hit, 1d6 + 3 Radiant; once per round Sprig can take the Help action as a Bonus Action.

Time trims

- For a two-hour game, make the moon-hen challenge 3 successes before 2 setbacks and remove the sugar-sprite fight.
- For a ninety-minute game, narrate the Windmill and Honey Steps, then run only the storehouse and Founder's Hearth finale.
- If any fight runs long, the remaining creatures surrender or bargain as soon as half are defeated and a hero offers terms.

Closing the session

Award the Restorer's Medal, ask when the players first suspected the answer, and let every hero describe one decoration before the birthday hero names the finished creation.

GM REFERENCE — EXPECT 3½ TO 4½ HOURS

Four-Hour Run Sheet

Clock	Scene	Target	End the scene when...
0:00–0:20	Bellweather Square	Meet heroes; accept commission	Every hero answers one spotlight question.
0:20–1:00	Briar Farm	Recover Dawn Pearls	Rooster is calmed or three hens fall.
1:00–1:15	BREAK 1 / SHORT REST	One-hour story transition; spend Hit Dice	Short Rest features recover; Musician can inspire allies.
1:15–2:00	Storehouse	Expose impostor; claim Lantern Gold	Correct flask is secured.
2:00–2:30	Windmill	Solve order; claim Sunmeal	Drawer opens.
2:30–3:00	Honey Steps	Earn Cloudsweet	Sprites bargain, befriend, or yield.
3:00–3:15	BREAK 2 / LONG REST	Eight-hour story transition; resume at dawn	HP, Hit Dice, spell slots, and Long Rest features recover.
3:15–3:45	Hearth Trials	Place components; each hero operates a station	All three preparation contributions are resolved.
3:45–4:20	Cindermaw Finale	Protect runes; complete or reconcile	Finish the current victory round.
4:20–4:30	Reveal	Name and celebrate the creation	Every hero adds one decoration.

AT EVERY SCENE

1. State the goal. 2. Describe what is obvious. 3. Ask every player what they do. 4. Roll only when failure changes something. 5. Give the clue or component even after a setback. 6. Announce the next destination.

IF THE CLOCK SLIPS

Do not remove a puzzle. Shorten combat: enemies bargain after half are defeated; use average damage; skip reinforcements. At the finale, Cindermaw offers terms after the next compassionate action.

Choices That Matter

Scene choice	Award	Later effect
Calm the rooster	Silver Feather	End Frightened on the whole party once.
Preserve Captain Wick's trust	Captain's Whistle	Guard one rune for a full round.
Solve the mill without magical hint	Millkeeper's Gear	Turn one failed preparation check into a success.
Make a sincere promise to sprites	Sprite's Favor	Advantage on first check to reason with Cindermaw.
Correctly predict the lost creation	Brilliant Deduction	Advantage on one Founder's Hearth check.

Three-Step Hint Ladder

Puzzle	Hint 1	Hint 2	Answer / final rescue
Windmill	Which symbol cannot be first?	Place CROWN immediately before SUN.	RIVER, RAVEN, CROWN, SUN.
Four Channels	What wakes must enter first.	Warm gold comes after form.	PEARLS, MEAL, GOLD, SWEET.
Hearth actions	Warming cannot happen before combining.	The crown must be last.	COMBINE, STIR, WARM, CROWN.

CINDERMAW FORESHADOWING

Farm: a drake silhouette watches from a chimney. Storehouse: the impostor gasps, 'The hearth leaves no room for us.' Windmill: soot reads, 'The hearth burns what it cannot remember.' Finale: Cindermaw's first words reveal fear, not hatred.

OFFLINE BINDER — DO THIS BEFORE PLAY

Ten-Minute GM Rehearsal

Minutes	Rehearse or prepare
0–2	Read the Bellweather Square and Briar Farm read-aloud boxes aloud once.
2–4	Locate the moon-hen, disguised sootling, sprite, sootling, and Cindermaw stat blocks.
4–6	Lay out the Storehouse zones and practise marking 3 successes / 2 setbacks.
6–8	Place four rune tokens, MIX / RISE / FINISH, Cindermaw, and two sootlings on the Hearth map.
8–10	Cover the real cake or reveal prop; rehearse lifting the cover after the final narration.

BIRTHDAY & FOOD CHECK

Privately confirm allergies, dietary needs, candles, and serving plans with a parent or guardian. Keep food packaging, scent, and the covered cake away from the play table so they do not reveal the mystery.

SPOTLIGHT RULE

At every challenge, ask all three players what they intend to do before resolving the first roll. Everyone acts before anyone repeats a skill or station.

REST RESET

BREAK 1 / SHORT REST: spend Hit Point Dice; recover Short Rest features; Elio's Musician feat can grant Heroic Inspiration.
BREAK 2 / LONG REST: restore HP, Hit Point Dice, spell slots, and Long Rest features; resume at dawn.

EMERGENCY FINISH

If time runs short after round 3 of the finale, the next successful compassionate or creative action advances Reconstruction to FINISH. Complete that round, then begin the reveal.

Challenge Procedures

Storehouse: 3 Successes Before 2 Setbacks

Route	Suggested checks	A success reveals...
OFFICIAL	DC 12 Insight, Perception, Persuasion	A contradiction, soot trail, or missing shadow.
COVERT	DC 13 Stealth, Acrobatics, thieves' tools	A safe path through rafters or the roof vent.
BAIT	DC 12 Deception, Investigation, Performance	The impostor's reaction or wooden-spoon seal.

STOREHOUSE OUTCOME
3 successes: expose the impostor cleanly and preserve Wick's trust. 2 setbacks: trigger the blue-fire chase. Either result secures Lantern Gold. Award the Whistle if no real guard was harmed.

Hearth Preparation: One Check Per Hero

Successes	Finale setup
3	All runes lit; Cinderdaw starts at 42 HP.
2	All runes lit; Cinderdaw starts at 52 HP.
1	One rune dark; Cinderdaw starts at 52 HP.
0	One rune dark; Cinderdaw acts first.

MILLKEEPER'S GEAR
After all three heroes contribute, convert one failed preparation check into a success. Resolve the row above only after every hero has acted.

GM REFERENCE — KEEP VISIBLE

Finale Dashboard & Initiative Strips

PLAYER VICTORY CARD

KEEP AT LEAST 2 RUNES LIT.
Complete MIX, RISE, and FINISH.
Only one different hero attempts Reconstruction each round.
After 2 successes and during round 3 or later, Cindermau can be offered a home.
Victory takes effect after everyone finishes the current round.

Round	Lit runes	Hero attempting Reconstruction	Progress / result
1	P _ M _ G _ S _	_____	_____
2	P _ M _ G _ S _	_____	_____
3	P _ M _ G _ S _	_____	_____
4	P _ M _ G _ S _	_____	_____
5	P _ M _ G _ S _	_____	_____

Initiative Strips — Cut Apart

BRAMBLE	NYX	ELIO	CINDERMAW
MOON-HENS	DISGUISED SOOTLING	SUGAR SPRITES	SOOTLINGS

✂ Cut on the cell borders and arrange the strips in initiative order.

GM Map Key: Briar Farm

RUNNING NOTES

Secret: feed in B3 grants Advantage to calm the rooster. Reinforcements enter from B9 only if the heroes dominate the first two rounds.

B1 RAFTERS DC 12 climb	B2 STONE NEST Dawn Pearls	B3 HAYLOFT hidden feed
B4 TROUGHS difficult terrain	B5 FARMYARD rooster + 3 hens	B6 SIDE GATE DC 12 latch
B7 OLD WELL Half Cover	B8 BARN DOORS heroes enter	B9 ORCHARD optional reinforcements

GM Map Key: Storehouse

RUNNING NOTES

Secret: the disguised sootling begins in S8, casts no shadow, and flees through S9 after two setbacks. The roof vent from S5 opens into S6.

S1 CITY WALL watch post	S2 ROOF WALK real guard	S3 CHIMNEY soot clue
S4 COURTYARD Captain Wick	S5 RAFTERS DC 13 crossing	S6 OIL ROOM wooden-spoon seal
S7 FRONT GATE official route	S8 SUPPLY HALL impostor begins	S9 ALLEY EXIT chase route

GM Map Key: Founder's Hearth

RUNNING NOTES

Start sootlings at H1 and H3. Adjacent keyed zones connect horizontally, vertically, or diagonally. Moving one zone costs up to 30 feet. Only one rune can be extinguished each round.

H1 PEARL RUNE	H2 CHIMNEY Cindermaw	H3 MEAL RUNE
H4 Pillars Half Cover	H5 DOME / TABLET Reconstruction	H6 Stone Hands Half Cover
H7 GOLD RUNE	H8 ENTRY heroes	H9 SWEET RUNE

NPC & Creature Stat Blocks

HOW TO USE THESE

Each block contains everything needed at the table. Mark current HP beside the printed maximum. For a faster game, use average damage instead of rolling. Creatures flee, surrender, or become harmless when the story says the encounter is over.

Mayor Mallow

Medium humanoid (human), neutral good

Armor Class 10 • Initiative +0 (10) • Hit Points 9 (2d8) • Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	14 (+2)	13 (+1)	15 (+2)

Skills History +4, Persuasion +4 • Senses passive Perception 11 • Languages Common, Dwarvish • Challenge 0 (10 XP; PB +2)

Town Historian. Mayor Mallow has advantage on Intelligence (History) checks about Bellweather.

Actions

Walking Stick. Melee Attack Roll: +2 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 2 (1d4) bludgeoning damage.

Rallying Word (1/Day). One creature within 30 ft. gains 5 temporary hit points.

Captain Wick

Medium humanoid (human), lawful good

Armor Class 16 (chain shirt, shield) • Initiative +1 (11) • Hit Points 27 (5d8+5) • Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	13 (+1)

Skills Insight +4, Investigation +2, Perception +4 • Senses passive Perception 14 • Languages Common • Challenge 1 (200 XP; PB +2)

Watch Captain. Friendly guards within 30 ft. have advantage on saves against frightened.

Actions

Multiattack. Wick makes two Spear attacks.

Spear. Melee or Ranged Attack Roll: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft. Hit: 5 (1d6+2) piercing damage.

Net (1/Day). Ranged Attack Roll: +3 to hit, range 5/15 ft. A Large or smaller target is restrained; escape DC 10.

NPC & Creature Stat Blocks — Continued

Bellweather Guard

Medium humanoid (any ancestry), any lawful alignment

Armor Class 14 (leather, shield) • Initiative +1 (11) • Hit Points 11 (2d8+2) • Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
13 (+1)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)

Skills Perception +2 • Senses passive Perception 12 • Languages Common • Challenge 1/8 (25 XP; PB +2)

Nonlethal Training. A guard reduced to 0 HP during this adventure is knocked unconscious and stable.

Actions

Spear. Melee or Ranged Attack Roll: +3, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft. Hit: 4 (1d6 + 1) Piercing damage.

Net (1/Day). Dexterity Saving Throw: DC 11, one Large or smaller creature within 15 feet. Failure: the target has the Restrained condition until it escapes (DC 10).

Moon-Hen

Small beast, unaligned

Armor Class 12 • Initiative +2 (12) • Hit Points 7 (2d6) • Speed 30 ft., fly 10 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
8 (-1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	3 (-4)	12 (+1)	7 (-2)

Skills Perception +3 • Senses passive Perception 13 • Languages — • Challenge 1/8 (25 XP; PB +2)

Flock Fury. The moon-hen has advantage on an attack roll if another moon-hen is within 5 ft. of the target.

Actions

Furious Peck. Melee Attack Roll: +4, reach 5 ft. Hit: 4 (1d4 + 2) Piercing damage.

Wing Flurry (Rooster Only; 1/Round). Dexterity Saving Throw: DC 12, each creature within 5 feet. Failure: 4 (1d4 + 2) Bludgeoning damage, and the target has the Prone condition.

NPC & Creature Stat Blocks — Continued

Disguised Sootling

Small elemental, chaotic neutral

Armor Class 13 • Initiative +2 (12) • Hit Points 13 (3d6+3) • Speed 30 ft., climb 20 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
8 (-1)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	9 (-1)	11 (+0)	12 (+1)
Skills Deception +3, Stealth +4 • Damage Resistances fire • Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10 • Languages understands Common • Challenge 1/4 (50 XP; PB +2)					

False Appearance. While motionless in guard form, the sootling is indistinguishable from a guard except that it casts no shadow and leaves soot tracks.
Soot Shape. As a Bonus Action, it changes between its soot form and one humanoid disguise.

Actions

Smudging Claw. Melee Attack Roll: +4, reach 5 ft. Hit: 5 (1d6 + 2) Psychic damage.
Blue-Fire Dash (Recharge 5–6). The sootling moves up to its Speed without provoking Opportunity Attacks.

Sugar Sprite

Tiny fey, chaotic good

Armor Class 13 • Initiative +3 (13) • Hit Points 4 (3d4-3) • Speed 10 ft., fly 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
4 (-3)	16 (+3)	9 (-1)	11 (+0)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)
Skills Nature +2, Performance +4 • Senses passive Perception 11 • Languages Common, Sylvan • Challenge 1/4 (50 XP; PB +2)					

Flower Step. Opportunity attacks against the sprite are made with disadvantage while it is within 5 ft. of a plant.

Actions

Sugar Sting. Melee or Ranged Attack Roll: +5, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft. Hit: 5 (1d4+3) Piercing damage.
Blinding Glitter (Recharge 6). Constitution Saving Throw: DC 12, one creature within 20 feet. Failure: the target has the Blinded condition until the start of the sprite's next turn.

NPC & Creature Stat Blocks — Continued

Sootling

Tiny elemental, chaotic neutral

Armor Class 12 • Initiative +2 (12) • Hit Points 5 (2d4) • Speed 25 ft., climb 25 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
6 (-2)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	7 (-2)	10 (+0)	8 (-1)

Damage Resistances fire • Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10 • Languages understands Ignan • Challenge 1/8 (25 XP; PB +2)

Poof! When reduced to 0 HP, the sootling bursts harmlessly. One creature within 5 ft. can catch its spark and regain 1d4 HP.

Actions

Smudging Scratch. Melee Attack Roll: +4, reach 5 ft. Hit: 4 (1d4 + 2) Psychic damage.

Foul Rune. The sootling extinguishes one unguarded hearth rune within 5 feet.

Cindermaw, Ash Drake

Medium elemental, chaotic neutral

Armor Class 14 • Initiative +3 (13) • Hit Points 52 (8d8+16) • Speed 30 ft., climb 20 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	9 (-1)	12 (+1)	13 (+1)

Saving Throws Dex +5, Wis +3 • Skills Acrobatics +5, Insight +3 • Damage Resistances fire • Condition Immunities frightened • Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 11 • Languages Common, Ignan • Challenge 2 (450 XP; PB +2)

Hearthbound. If no sootling used Foul Rune this round, Cindermaw extinguishes one lit, unguarded rune at round's end. Only one rune can be extinguished per round.

Fear of Extinction. After 2 Reconstruction successes and no earlier than round 3, a creature can use an action and succeed on a DC 12 Charisma (Persuasion) check to offer Cindermaw a home. The fight ends after the current round.

Actions

Cinder Claw. Melee Attack Roll: +5, reach 5 ft. Hit: 7 (1d8 + 3) Fire damage.

Soot Breath (Recharge 5-6). Wisdom Saving Throw: DC 13, each creature in a 15-foot Cone. Failure: 7 (2d6) Psychic damage, and the target has the Frightened condition until the end of its next turn. Success: Half damage only.

Reactions

Up the Chimney. Trigger: Cindermaw is hit by an attack. Response: Cindermaw climbs up to 10 feet without provoking Opportunity Attacks.

Sprig, Lantern Sprite

Tiny fey, neutral good

Armor Class 13 • Initiative +3 (13) • Hit Points 15 (6d4) • Speed 10 ft., fly 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
5 (-3)	16 (+3)	10 (+0)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	13 (+1)

Skills Perception +4 • Damage Resistances radiant • Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 14 • Languages Common, Sylvan • Challenge 1/4 (50 XP; PB +2)

Helpful Light. Sprig can take the Help action as a Bonus Action.

Actions

Star Bolt. Ranged Spell Attack Roll: +4, range 60 ft. Hit: 5 (1d6 + 2) Radiant damage.

Kindle (1/Day). Sprig relights one hearth rune within 30 feet.